

The main relationships are listed as friends, friends of friends, and friends of friends of friends (in essence, strangers). There is also the exposure to the entire network or community of persons. These ratings of friends are also given the term “degrees”, and can be thought of as a type of weighting. People are unlikely to want people five degrees away to contact them or their own friends, so the viewing needs to be controlled. Viewing can be controlled on these sites by the individual members as to who can reach them and who their information will be available to through controls and settings within the sites themselves. Users are allowed to see profiles that can be set to the maximum or minimum number of degrees away. A friend is defined as someone whose company and attitudes one finds sympathetic and to whom one is closely related. The orkut site has a friendship barometer that lets members rate their relationship to another member based on their actual relationship with that person: haven’t met, acquaintance, friend, good friend, and best friend. orkut has a linear scale of friendships, but it is not detailed enough as there is not enough meta-data as to what exactly it is that quantifies a friend.

LinkedIn masks a member’s contacts, and they need to request the contact or in some cases to have outside contact with the other party. Networks from Ryze and Tribe to Friendster and orkut are explicit in that both interests and people are easily connected to others both through their photos and browsable links. However, there are limits, for example Friendster relationships are defined by referrals, so that a member can only browse four degrees away and not the entire network.

2.3 Business Models and Potential Profitability

Social networking sites have low overheads and aggregate large quantities of valuable information through user profiles, ranging from their favorite books to movies, and such information can be targeted for very specific advertising. A number of these sites have classifieds and even advertise openings for job opportunities. Some business networking sites like LinkedIn will perhaps prove to be more profitable. LinkedIn offers many valuable features to